

EMPLOYEE SENTIMENT & CULTURE

# What Really Makes Employees Recommend Their Employer

A People Analytics diagnostic across 838,000 UK Glassdoor reviews

# The bottom line, in one slide

## THE PROBLEM

**29%**

of employees would not recommend their employer

For a 1,000-person org that is an estimated £1.15–2.69M in annual cost exposure.

## WHAT DRIVES IT

**Culture**

& leadership, not pay

Culture is the strongest driver (odds 2.46). Compensation is only secondary — a hygiene factor.

## THE RECOMMENDATION

**Fix  
leadership**

first, and together with culture

Higher impact and lower cost than blanket pay rises. Prove it with a randomized pilot before scaling.

## THE PROBLEM

# Low advocacy is a financial problem, not just a reputational one

**29%**

would not recommend

**16%**

rate 2 stars or below

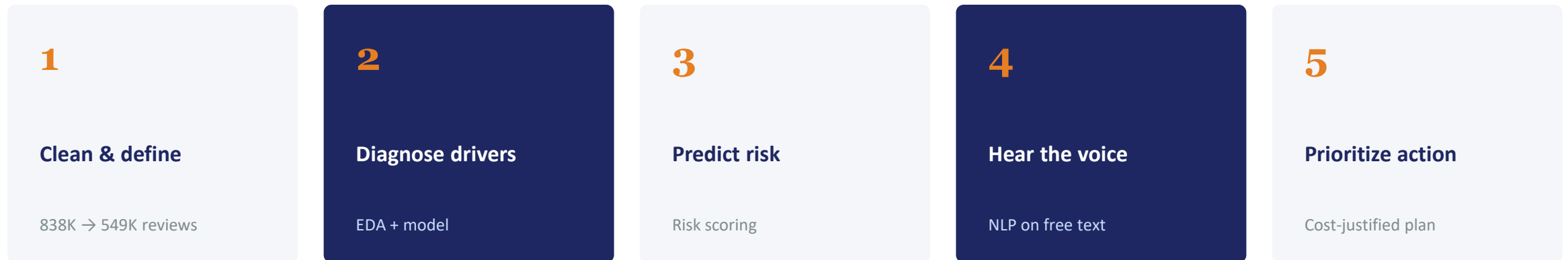
**£1.15–2.69M**

annual cost / 1,000 staff

### Why it costs money

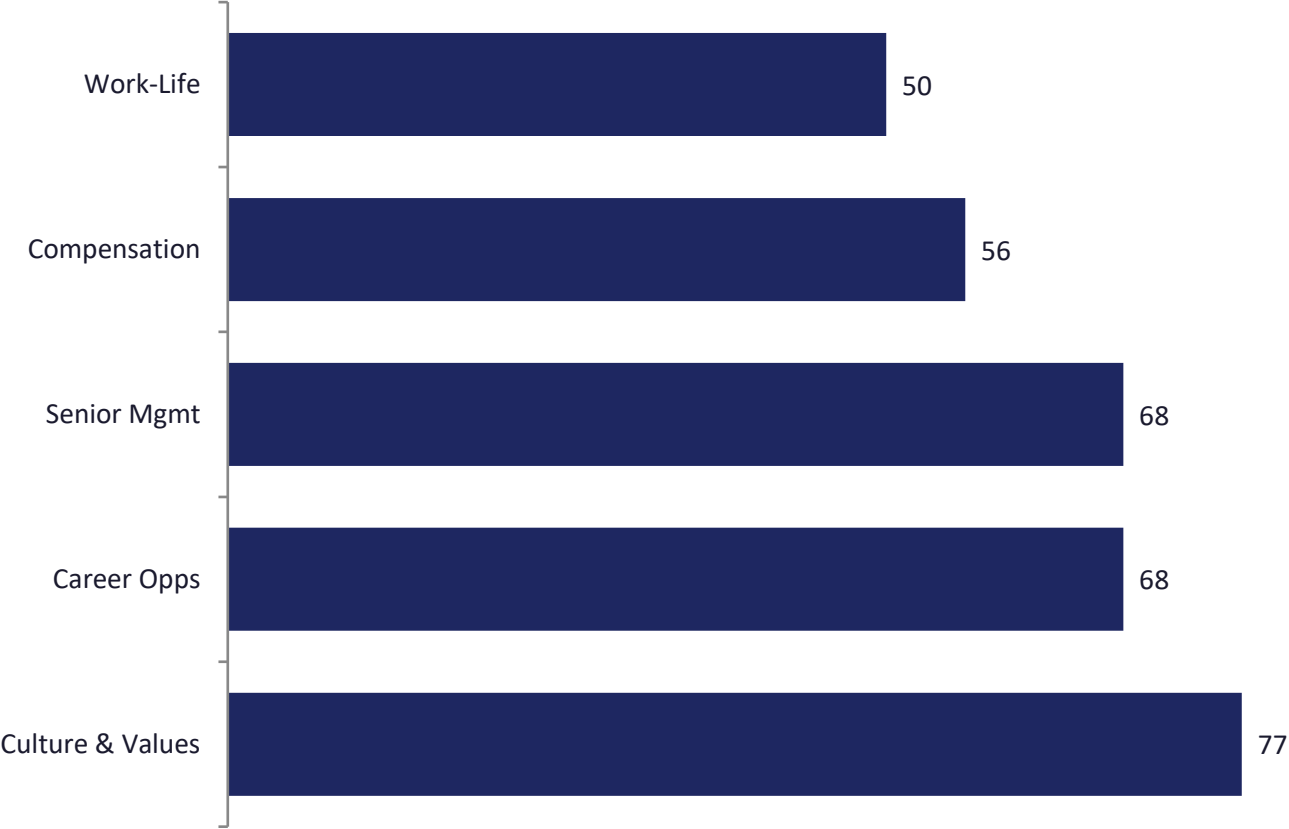
Gallup puts the cost of one actively disengaged employee at roughly 34% of their annual salary — lost productivity, absenteeism, and higher turnover risk. Employees who actively would not recommend their employer are disproportionately the disengaged and the soon-to-leave.

# From raw reviews to prioritized action, in five steps



FINDING 1

# Culture is the strongest driver of whether people recommend



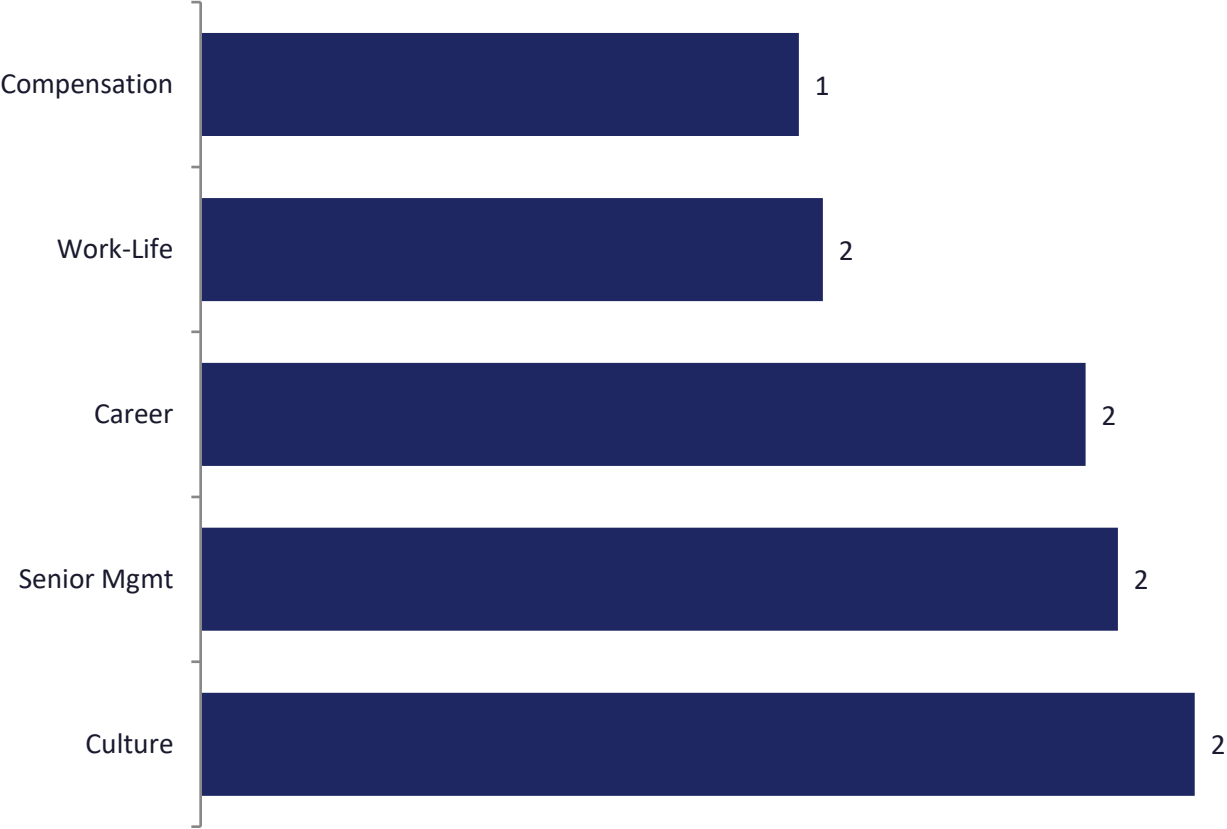
77 pts

The gap for Culture & Values

People who rate culture poorly almost never recommend. Those who rate it highly almost always do. Compensation ranks only fourth — pay frustrates in its absence but doesn't win advocacy on its own.

FINDING 2

Even after controlling for everything else, culture stays on top



2.46x

Culture's independent effect

A one-step lift in culture raises the odds of recommending 2.46x, holding leadership, career, pay and work-life constant. Two methods agree on the ranking — that is what makes it trustworthy. Pay lands last.

FINDING 3

# In their own words: bad management is the dealbreaker



Detractors mention management 2.5× more than promoters. Promoters complain about hours 2.6× more — yet still recommend. Rough conditions are tolerated; bad management is not.

# When culture and leadership both fail, advocacy collapses

98%

recommend when culture  
AND leadership are strong

vs

12%

recommend when both  
are weak

*A second failing factor does far more damage than the first. Where both are weak, they must be fixed together — not one at a time.*



# We can flag a would-not-recommend review with 86% recall

0.86

Recall on detractors

0.94

ROC-AUC

Logistic

Chosen model — interpretable

## Why these choices

### Optimized for recall

Missing a detractor is costly; a false alarm only costs a conversation.

### Chose the interpretable model

Random Forest was only ~0.1% better — not worth losing explainable odds.

### Honest about the scores

High accuracy partly reflects that ratings and the recommend decision share the same sentiment.

# Three tiers that HR can actually act on

| Risk band | % of people | Actual detractor rate | Action                    |
|-----------|-------------|-----------------------|---------------------------|
| High      | 30%         | 78%                   | Prioritize — engage first |
| Medium    | 15%         | 26%                   | Lighter-touch monitoring  |
| Low       | 56%         | 3.5%                  | No active intervention    |

Well calibrated: the High band holds 30% of people but 78% of them are genuine detractors. HR effort lands on real risk, not noise. About 22% are false alarms — an accepted trade-off, since missing a detractor costs far more than a needless conversation.

# Target the weakness, not the demographic

## Former employees

39.6% land High-risk vs 23.2% of current — but they have already left.

## A diagnostic, not a target

Former-employee feedback shows what drives people out.

## Current, weak on culture

Defined, reachable, and ready for intervention.

## Tenure doesn't sharpen it

Recommend rates stay flat (76–78%) across tenure — so target by driver.

**The actionable unit is not 'which people' but 'which weakness' — current employees rating culture or leadership poorly, pointed straight at the fix.**

# Sequenced by impact, with the trade-offs in the open



**Benchmark first: pay is a secondary driver, so no blanket pay rises. Impact-over-efficiency, stated openly.**

## Sizing the opportunity honestly

### THE EXPOSURE

**£1.15M**

annual cost tied to ~290 high-risk employees in a 1,000-person org (Gallup 34%-of-salary).



### THE LEVER

**Low-capital**

Leadership and culture change is mostly behaviour and process, not spend. Manager capability, not payroll.

*Figures size the opportunity under stated assumptions — illustrative exposure, not guaranteed ROI. The true effect is confirmed by the pilot.*

## A phased rollout that proves impact before it scales



The ask: approve a 3-month pilot on the highest-risk teams. Low cost, clear success metric, and the evidence to scale with confidence.